Three Mistakes Families Make When the Care Arrangement Seems to Be Working

What each one looks like, why it happens, and the habit to put in its place.

These three are easy to fall into precisely because things are going all right. None of them is anyone's fault, and each one has a small habit that replaces it.

1 Treating a heavy load as normal

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE Someone asks how you're managing and you say, “Oh, it's fine, it's just what you do.” Meanwhile his pills, the driving and the calls to the doctor's office have all become yours since last year.

WHY IT HAPPENS The work arrived one task at a time, so no single addition looked like much. The Family Caregiver Alliance describes caregiving starting with small things, to the point that a person may not even identify as a caregiver at first. [1]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Answer one small question: what has gotten harder? Write the week down, small things included, and mark what is new or has changed in the last year. Then show it to one person you trust and ask whether it looks like your week to them. The list doesn't say the load is too much. It shows you its size.

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2 Assuming missed tasks will sort themselves out

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE A refill gets picked up a few days late, twice. The gutters somebody mentioned in the spring are still on nobody's list. Each time, everyone figures it was a one-off.

WHY IT HAPPENS In a family arrangement, a lot of the work happens because someone assumed someone else would do it. The Family Caregiver Alliance says families often don't think through who becomes the primary caregiver and what supporting roles the others will play, and, writing about siblings who share a parent's care, that the others may assume the main caregiver has everything covered. [1]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Ask where responsibilities are unclear. Sort the tasks into three piles: clearly someone's job, assumed but never discussed, and nobody's yet. Then ask about one of them, plainly. The Family Caregiver Alliance's advice is to be clear and specific, and not to hint or hope the other person will guess. [2]

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3 Saving the hard conversation for later

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE There's a subject you rehearse in the car and don't raise at Sunday dinner. You tell yourself you'll bring it up when things settle down, or when there's a reason to.

WHY IT HAPPENS It never feels like the moment. AARP's planning guide for families says these conversations are easy to put off because they can be difficult, and that it never seems like the right time to bring up an uncomfortable topic. [3]

> **WHAT TO DO INSTEAD** Choose the one disagreement the family most wants talked through, and give it a date and a narrow subject. The National Institute on Aging says a family conversation about care is most productive when there is not an emergency, which is the kind of week you're in now. One meeting doesn't have to settle it. The Family Caregiver Alliance says the meeting is not a one-time event, so keep a list of what is still open. [4] [5]

The one habit behind all three

Put it on paper while things are working: the week as it is, who has agreed to what, and the one conversation to have soon.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say whether your arrangement is working, whether the load is too much, or whether your husband needs more help. It names three habits, which are the same three the Family Care Roadmap sees at this step.

Ready for the next step?

You know which three habits to drop and what to put in their place. The care interview builds on that with a structured look at your husband's needs and the help around him, area by area, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

The descriptions of how caregiving starts, what relatives assume and why hard conversations get put off come from the sources below, as does the advice to ask clearly, to talk when there is no emergency and to expect more than one meeting. The three mistakes are the Family Care Roadmap's own.

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving with Your Siblings
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Taking Care of YOU: Self-Care for Family Caregivers
3. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
4. National Institute on Aging, Sharing Caregiving Responsibilities
5. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting

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